



False cognate

False cognates are pairs of words that seem to be cognates because of similar sounds or spelling and meaning, but have different etymologies; they can be within the same language or from different languages, even within the same family.^[1] For example, the English word *dog* and the Mbabaram word *dog* have exactly the same meaning and very similar pronunciations, but by complete coincidence. Likewise, English *much* and Spanish *mucho* came by their similar meanings via completely different Proto-Indo-European roots, and same for English *have* and Spanish *haber*. This is different from false friends, which are similar-sounding words with different meanings, and may or may not be cognates. Within a language, if they are spelled the same, they are homographs; if they are pronounced the same, they are homophones. Cross-linguistic or interlingual homographs or homophones sometimes include cognates; non-cognates may more specifically be called homographic or homophonic noncognates.^[2]

Even though false cognates lack a common root, there may still be an indirect connection between them (for example by phono-semantic matching or folk etymology).

Phenomenon

The term "false cognate" is sometimes misused to refer to false friends, but the two phenomena are distinct.^{[1][3]} False friends occur when two words in different languages or dialects look similar, but have different meanings. While some false friends are also false cognates, many are genuine cognates (see False friends § Causes).^[3] For example, English *pretend* and French *prétendre* are false friends, but not false cognates, as they have the same origin.^[4]

"Mama and papa" type

The basic kinship terms mama and papa constitute a special case of false cognates; many languages share words of similar form and meaning for these kinship terms, but due to common processes of language acquisition rather than relatedness of the languages.^{[5][6][7][8]}

Examples

Note: Some etymologies may be simplified to avoid overly long descriptions.

Within English

Term 1	Etymology 1	Term 2	Etymology 2
day	Old English <i>dæg</i> << Proto-Germanic <i>*dagaz</i> << Proto-Indo-European <i>*dʰegʰ</i> . ^[9]	diary	Latin <i>dīārium</i> << <i>dies</i> ("day") << Proto-Italic <i>*djēm</i> << PIE <i>*dyéws</i> ("heaven") ^[10] ^[11]
island	Middle English <i>iland</i> << Old English <i>īegland</i> << Proto-Germanic <i>*awjōlandą</i>	isle	Middle English <i>ile</i> << Old French <i>i(s)le</i> << Latin <i>insula</i>
(government) policy ^[12]	Middle English <i>policie</i> << Old French <i>policie</i> << Late Latin <i>politia</i> << Ancient Greek <i>politeía</i>	(insurance) policy	French <i>police</i> << Italian <i>polizza</i> << Medieval Latin <i>apodissa</i> << Ancient Greek <i>apódeixis</i>

Between English and other languages

English term	English etymology	Foreign term	Foreign etymology
bad	Possibly from OE <i>bæddel</i> ("hermaphrodite, effeminate man") << PGmc <i>*bad-</i> ("defile")	Persian بد, <i>bad</i> ^{[13][11]}	Middle Iranian <i>*vat</i> << PIE <i>*wed(h)-</i>
better	OE <i>betera</i>	Persian بهتر, <i>behtar</i> and Hindustani descendants	به (<i>beh</i> , "good") + تر (<i>-tar</i> , "-er")
cinder	OE <i>sinder</i> << PGmc <i>*sendra-</i> "slag" << PIE <i>*sendhro-</i> "coagulating fluid"	French <i>cendre</i> ("ash")	Latin <i>cinerem</i> << PIE <i>*ken-</i> ("to arise, begin")
day	OE <i>dæg</i> << PGmc <i>*dagaz</i> << PIE <i>*dʰegʰ</i> ^[9]	Latin <i>dies</i> ("day") and descendants ^{[10][11]}	Proto-Italic <i>*djēm</i> << PIE <i>*dyēws</i> ("heaven") ^{[10][11]}
desert	Latin <i>dēserō</i> ("to abandon") << ultimately PIE <i>*seh₁-</i> ("to sow")	Ancient Egyptian <i>Deshret</i> (refers to the land not flooded by the Nile)	from <i>dšr</i> (red)
dog	OE <i>docga</i> or <i>dogga</i>	Mbabaram <i>dog</i> ("dog") ^[11]	Proto-Pama-Nyungan <i>*gudaga</i>
<u>emoticon</u>	<i>emotion</i> + <i>icon</i>	Japanese (emoji) ^[14]	(<i>e</i>) ("picture") + (<i>moji</i>) ("character") ^[14]
have	Middle English <i>haven</i> << OE <i>habban</i> ("to have") << Proto-West Germanic <i>*habbian</i> << Proto-Germanic <i>*habjaną</i> ("to have"), durative of <i>*habjaną</i> ("to lift, take up") << PIE <i>*kh₂pyéti</i> present tense of <i>*keh₂p-</i> ("to take, seize, catch").	Corsican <i>avè</i> ("to have")	Latin <i>habēre</i> , present active infinitive of <i>habēō</i> << Proto-Italic <i>*habēō</i> << PIE <i>*gʰeh₁bʰ-</i> ("to grab").
hollow	OE <i>holh</i> << PGmc <i>*holhwo-</i>	Lake Miwok <i>hóllu</i> ^[13]	
much	OE <i>mycel</i> << PGmc <i>*mikilaz</i> << PIE <i>*megá-</i> ("big, stout, great")	Spanish <i>mucho</i> ("much") ^[11]	Latin <i>multus</i> (many) << PIE <i>*młtos</i> ("crumbled")
<u>saint</u>	Latin <i>sanctus</i> << PIE <i>*seh₂k-</i> ("to sanctify") via French	Sanskrit <i>sant</i> and descendants ^[15]	<i>sat</i> ("truth, reality, essence")
shark	Middle English <i>shark</i> from uncertain origin	Chinese (shā)	Named as its crude skin is similar to sand ((shā))

Between other languages

Term 1	Etymology 1	Term 2	Etymology 2
French <i>feu</i> ("fire")	Latin <i>focus</i>	German <i>Feuer</i> ("fire")	PGmc <i>*fōr</i> ~ <i>*fun-</i> ^{[9][16][11]} << PIE <i>*péh₂wṛ</i>
French <i>nuque</i> ('nape')	Latin <i>nucha</i> , from Arabic نُخَاع <i>nukhā'</i> 'spinal marrow'	Hungarian <i>nyak</i> ('neck') ^[17]	Proto-Uralic <i>*ńɣkkɜ</i> 'neck'
German <i>haben</i> ('to have')	PG <i>*habjaną</i> << PIE <i>*keh₂p-</i> ("to grasp")	Latin <i>habere</i> ("to have") and descendants ^[18]	PIE <i>*gʰeh₁bʰ-</i> ("to grab, to take")
Swedish <i>göl</i> ("pool")	PG <i>*guljō</i>	Salar <i>göl</i> ("pool")	Proto-Turkic <i>*kōl</i> ("lake")
German <i>Erdbeere</i> ('strawberry')	<i>Erd</i> ('earth') + <i>Beere</i> ('berry')	Hungarian <i>eper</i> ('strawberry') ^[17]	
German <i>Haus</i> ('house')		Hungarian <i>ház</i> ('house') ^[17]	
Hawaiian <i>kahuna</i> ('priest')		Hebrew כֹּהֵן (<i>kohen</i>) ('priest') ^[19]	
Hungarian <i>nő</i> ('woman')		Mandarin Chinese (<i>nǚ</i>) ('woman') ^[17]	
Inuktitut ᑭᓴᑦ (<i>kayak</i>)	Proto-Eskimo <i>*qyaq</i>	Turkish <i>kayık</i> ('small boat') ^[20]	Old Turkic <i>kayguk</i> << Proto-Turkic <i>kay-</i> ("to slide, to turn")
Mayaimi <i>Mayaimi</i> (<i>Big water</i>)		Hebrew מַיִם <i>mayim</i> ("water")	
Japanese ありがとう <i>arigatō</i> ("thank you")	Clipping of う います "arigatō gozaimasu" ("(I) am thankful") << く "arigataku" << い "arigatai" ("thankful, appreciated") << Old Japanese "arigatasi" ("difficult to be")	Portuguese <i>obrigado</i> ("thank you") ^[21]	Literally "obliged" << Latin <i>obligātus</i>
Hindustani अम्मा / 𑂔𑂱𑂰 (<i>ammā</i> , "mother")	Prakrit 𑀅𑀲𑀭𑀸𑀓 (<i>aṃmā</i>), from Sanskrit अम्बा (<i>ambā</i> , "mother, feminine honorific")	Tamil அம்மா (<i>ammā</i> , "mother")	Proto-Dravidian <i>*amma</i> ("mother")
Indonesian <i>tanah</i> ("ground")	Proto-Austronesian <i>*tanaq</i>	Aleut <i>tanaĭ</i> ("ground")	Proto-Eskimo <i>*luna</i> ("earth")
Tagalog <i>bagay</i> ("thing")	Proto-Malayo-Polynesian <i>*bagay</i>	Haitian Creole <i>bagay</i> ("thing")	Saint Dominican Creole French <i>bagage</i>
Dusun <i>do</i> ("of")	Austronesian <i>o</i>	Portuguese <i>do</i> ("of")	Latin <i>de</i>
Spanish <i>gusano</i> ("worm, insect larva")	Uncertain, possibly from Latin <i>cossus</i> ("woodworm")	Russian <i>гусеница</i> (<i>gusenica</i>) ("caterpillar")	Proto-Slavic <i>*q̑sēnica</i> ("caterpillar")

False cognates used in the coinage of new words

The coincidental similarity between false cognates can sometimes be used in the creation of new words (neologization). For example, the Hebrew word דַּל *dal* ("poor") (which is a false cognate of the phono-semantically similar English word *dull*) is used in the new Israeli Hebrew expression אין רגע דל *en rega dal* (literally "There is no **poor** moment") as a phono-semantic matching for the English expression *Never a **dull** moment*.^[22]

Similarly, the Hebrew word דיבוב *dibúv* ("speech, inducing someone to speak"), which is a false cognate of (and thus etymologically unrelated to) the phono-semantically similar English word *dubbing*, is then used in the Israeli phono-semantic matching for *dubbing*. The result is that in Modern Hebrew, דיבוב *dibúv* means "dubbing".^[23]

See also

- Areal feature
- Convergent evolution
- Equivalence
- Etymological fallacy
- False etymology
- False friend
- Linguistic interference (language transfer)
- Pseudoscientific language comparison
- Semantic change
- Sprachbund

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